This chunky country soup takes minutes to prepare and makes a good light supper or lunch dish. For a vegetarian option, leave out the bacon.

french cabbage soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
WITHOUT THE BACON GARNISH

1 tbsp olive oil
3½oz (100g) diced bacon
1 Spanish onion, finely chopped
1 garlic clove, crushed
1 large Savoy cabbage, halved, core discarded, and leaves cut into shreds
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
3 sprigs of parsley
croûtons (see p39), to garnish

1 Heat the oil in a large heavy saucepan over medium heat. Add the bacon (setting aside 2 tbsp to garnish), onion, and garlic. Cook, stirring frequently, for 3–4 minutes or until the onion and garlic start to color. Add the cabbage shreds, reserving a handful to finish. Stir well and season lightly with sea salt and generously with pepper. Continue cooking for 2–3 minutes, stirring occasionally.

2 Bring about 3½ cups water to a boil in a teapot. Pour the boiling water over the vegetables and bacon pieces, stir well, and add the parsley. Cover, lower the heat a little, and simmer gently for about 20 minutes, stirring occasionally.

3 Meanwhile, place a nonstick cooking pan over medium heat. Add the reserved bacon and cook until crisp and golden. Then add the reserved cabbage shreds and cook them until they have wilted, stirring frequently. Season with a little pepper.

4 Taste the soup and adjust the seasoning as needed. Remove the parsley. Ladle into individual bowls and scatter the fried bacon and cabbage mixture over the top. Garnish with croûtons, if using, to finish off the soup.